I spoke. ‘See, Sasi is not my subordinate. He need not take any orders from me. Please also understand that he does not report to me administratively. In ISRO we have a matrix management system where there is a general hierarchy of seniors and juniors, but people are deputed under different projects and they report to different bosses. In one such project, the cryogenic project, Sasi is the deputy project director and I the project director. That does not make him my subordinate in ISRO.’

‘Are you saying Sasi is not your junior?’

‘He is. And it does not mean he is my subordinate.’

The next question shocked me, not because of its ingenuity, but as it related to a top secret operation ISRO was running with the knowledge of only a few people in the organisation and the Ministry of External Affairs. ‘Didn’t you bring the drawings and components of a cryogenic engine by Ural Aviation flights from Russia?’

It convinced me that my interrogators had been supplied with half-baked information by an external agency. This was to be a vital clue for me to understand later how the agency bought over a few Indian intelligence officers to fabricate the ISRO spy case and scuttle India’s efforts to develop a cryogenic engine. This was a crucial programme that would make India capable of not just interplanetary exploration, but also developing geosynchronous launch vehicles with higher capability. How I managed to bring some components and blueprints of a cryogenic engine when the US arm-twisted Russia into going back on a technology transfer deal is another tale of determination.

We chose Ural Aviation to do this since the Russians were more than willing to give the drawings and parts before the Americans did something more nasty, but our own Air India chickened out when asked to bring the consignment, since the national carrier feared the US would stop its trans-Atlantic operations to New York and Washington, and thus take away a big chunk of its revenue. Ural Aviation flew four times carrying in its belly hardware, components, valves and design drawings of a cryogenic engine from Moscow to Trivandrum.